

Lecture 07 (2026-07-05)

Quick Summary

Teams are preferred in organizational management to compete better by utilizing employee talent, offering flexibility, providing rapid deployment/refocusing, and facilitating participation in decisions. However, they can be susceptible to herd mentality. The distinction between a "group" and a "team" is critical: groups focus on information sharing and diversity, while teams focus on collective performance and positive synergy. Team success is driven by specific roles (e.g., Creator, Linker, Maintainer), clear mental models, and social dynamics like equality in communication and high social sensitivity. A critical driver of team success is **Psychological Safety**, which outweighs individual traits or personalities. Communication serves as a vital tool for not just sharing information, but also for controlling behavior, fostering motivation through understanding, and providing a release for emotional expression. **Communication effectiveness is heavily influenced by "Channel Richness" (the availability of cues like tone and feedback) and the ability to navigate personal perception barriers.**

Key Definitions

Why Have Teams Become So Popular? * Offer a better way to use employee talents * Are more flexible and responsive to changing events * Can quickly assemble, deploy, refocus, and disband * Facilitate participation in operating decisions * Can be swayed by fads, herd mentality, leading astray

Types of Teams * **Problem Solving Teams:** Formed for a specific issue/goal (e.g., improving quality or efficiency). Typically 5-10 members from the same department meeting for a set period (e.g., 3 months). * **Self-managed Teams:** Teams that take on supervisory responsibilities (planning, scheduling) but often suffer from lack of authority, accountability, and higher rates of conflict/communication lapses. * **Cross-functional Teams:** Members from the same hierarchical level but from different departments (e.g., Marketing, Finance, Engineering) collaborating on a specific objective. * **Virtual Teams:** Physically dispersed members joined by technology. Requires significant effort to build trust and "market" individual contributions to the organization.

Team Effectiveness Model * **Context:** The environment/situation in which the team is situated. * **Composition:** Selection of members with complementary skills. * **Process:** The states/actions the team goes through. * **Assessment:** Periodic evaluation of whether the team remains necessary and effective.

Team Management & Dynamics * **Reward Systems:** Can be based on project, team purpose, or specific team output/appraisals. * **Continuity Plans:** Necessary to manage the transition if a "critical member" exits or cannot participate. * **Mental Models:** Shared understanding of who is doing what and the current status of the project. * **Team Identity:** The extent to which satisfied/happy employees identify with the team they work for. * **Cohesion:** Directly contributes to team productivity. * **Social Loafing:** A situation where some members "lay back" while others work hard; must be monitored and avoided. * **Social Sensitivity:** The ability to read others' feelings via non-verbal cues (tone of voice, expressions). * **Psychological Safety:** A climate where members feel safe to speak up, admit mistakes, and show their "true" selves. It is considered a more significant driver of success than individual ability or personality. * **Specific Team Roles:** * **Creator:** Provides innovative/out-of-the-box thinking; initiates "why don't we" ideas. * **Promoter:** Champions and promotes ideas; may not be the most creative/skilled but is skilled at "selling" the idea. * **Assessor:** Offers analysis of options; provides multiple ways to execute a goal (e.g., "option 1, 2, or 3"). * **Organizer:** Provides structure, handles logistics, and creates timelines (e.g., scheduling meetings). * **Producer:** Provides direction and follow-through; focuses on the "how many" and "when." * **Controller:** Examines details and ensures the team follows established rules. * **Maintainer:** Fights "external battles"; advocates for the team to higher-ups regarding delays or lapses.

* **Advisor:** Focuses on information seeking, detail orientation, and acting as a guide/mentor. * **Linker:** Coordinates/integrate with other teams; well-networked; knows whom to contact for help.

Communication Dynamics * **Communication Functions:** * **Control:** Influencing behavior through tone and authority. * **Motivation:** Fostering drive through meaning and understanding (not just via financial incentives). * **Emotional Expression:** Providing a safe space for members to release emotions (critical for team cohesion). * **Information:** Providing the data necessary to make informed decisions. * **Grapevine:** An informal communication network. It often contains rumors. While not necessarily "wrong," it lacks the official "stamp" of the organization, which can cause ambiguity and anxiety. * **Oral Communication:** Speeches, formal discussions, informal rumor mills (Grapevine), meetings, video-conferencing, and telephone. * **Written Communication:** * **Formal Letters:** Carry heavy weight/importance. * **Presentations:** Facilitate discussing thought processes as viewers see information visually. * **Email:** Effective for long stories and evidence, but high risk of **tone misinterpretation**, leading to ambiguity and anxiety. * **Instant Messaging/Text:** Preferred for "handy," quick updates. * **Social Media:** Used for organizational branding/positioning and as a tool to gauge employee behavior/sentiment. * **Non-verbal Communication:** * **Components:** Body movements, intonations, emphasis, and facial expressions. * **Function:** Conveys status (power), level of engagement, and emotional state. * **Physical Distance:** Can indicate interest, anger, or disinterest; highly dependent on cultural norms. * **Barriers to Effective Communication (Screen Content):** * **Filtering:** A sender's manipulation of information to make it more favorable to the receiver. * **Selective Perception:** Interpreting information based on personal interests, background, experience, and attitude. * **Information Overload:** When the volume of information exceeds a receiver's processing capacity. * **Silence:** Absence of information due to employees' fear of being belittled or ignored for differing views. * **Communication Apprehension:** Tension, anxiety, or "tongue-tied" feelings regarding oral or written communication.

Worked Examples

How to Create Team Players (Step-by-Step Selection/Training Process): 1. **Selection:** Treat "team skills" as a specific interpersonal skill during the hiring process. Use a "weightage" or ranking system to identify which roles (Creator, Linker, etc.) a candidate is best suited for. 2. **Training:** Use specialists to conduct exercises that allow employees to experience the benefits of teamwork and become skilled at it. 3. **Rewards:** Shift reward structures to favor cooperative efforts over individual competition. Reward "being a team player" as a "brownie point" in appraisals while still acknowledging individual contributions. 4. **Overcoming "Tongue-Tied" Situations:** * **Public Speaking:** Training in large-scale public speaking can cause automatic drops in hesitation and shyness. * **Focus on Value:** Shift the focus of the individual to "adding value to the conversation" rather than just focusing on the problem. * **Management Support:** Managers can use "Round Robin" in small meetings to ensure everyone has a turn, or provide "Scripts" to technically-savvy introverts so they feel prepared to lead specific topics.

Case Study: Tongue-Tied in Teams (Robert Murphy) * **Scenario:** Robert (online marketing rep) is well-prepared and has notes but remains silent in a meeting of 7 people. * **Analysis of Failure to Speak:** * **Ability:** Some employees lack the skill to speak in front of others. * **Anxiety (The "Thinking Trap"):** A study shows that if individuals believe peers are smarter, they experience anxiety that blocks their ability to think effectively. * **Reasoning:** Worrying about what the group thinks of you makes you "dumber" because it consumes cognitive resources. * **Personality:** Introverts prefer to collect thoughts; however, even extroverts can remain silent if they feel they cannot contribute. * **Solutions/Interventions:** 1. **Pairing:** Match an individual with a more assertive peer who can "pull" them into the conversation. 2. **Prompting:** Use verbal cues like "Let's hear what Robert says" to give the individual the "courage" or permission to speak. 3. **Preparation:** Discuss thoughts with the meeting facilitator beforehand. 4. **Normalization:** Realize that others likely share the same anxieties. 5. **Focus vs. Pressure:** Shift focus from "pressure" (external judgment) to "internal goals" (the task at hand).

Navigating Listener Barriers (Lisa Geruzzi Methodology): * **Strategy for "WIIFM" (What's In It For Me?):** Listeners filter information through their own concerns. * **Action:** Use specific phrasing: "What

this means for you is..." * **Strategy for "Truth" vs. "Opinion":** Listeners often view their personal interpretations as absolute facts. * **Action:** Disarm the "defense" by speaking in terms of opinion. Use: "The way I see it..." or "In my experience..." * **Strategy for "Right-Wrong" Trap:** Listeners often view things as a binary (if you are right, they are wrong). * **Action:** Acknowledge multiple ways to achieve a goal. Use: "There are probably many ways to accomplish X, and we are choosing to do Y for the next three months, and then we'll reevaluate." * **Reasoning:** This allows them to accept the current path without feeling like they are conceding that it is the "only" correct way.

Formulas & Rules

Criteria for Determining if a Team is Necessary (The "Three Tests"): 1. **Complexity:** Is the work complex and does it require different perspectives? 2. **Common Purpose:** Does the work create a common purpose/goal larger than the sum of individual goals? 3. **Interdependence:** Are the members involved in interdependent tasks? * **Note:** A "Yes" to any or all of these justifies the resources/time required to maintain a team. If the task is routine/mundane, an individual approach is preferred.

Team Size Rules: * **Small Teams:** Used primarily for **decision making**. * **Large Teams:** Used primarily for **fact-finding** or **problem-solving**.

Project Aristotle (Success Metrics): * **Equality Rule:** Success is linked to "equality" in conversation. Team members should speak in roughly the same proportion. If only a few people speak all the time, "collective intelligence" declines. * **Social Sensitivity Rule:** Success is linked to high social sensitivity (the ability to read non-verbal cues).

Team Maturity Rule: * When comparing teams, the "age" (duration of existence) of the team must be accounted for. Newer teams may show more conflict due to surface-level differences; established teams reach a "steady state" where depth-level similarities are better established.

Communication Channel Selection Rule (Based on Risk/Benefit): * The choice of channel should be based on three criteria: 1. **Length:** How long is the message? 2. **Depth:** How deep is the message? 3. **Importance:** How important is the message?

Channel Richness Classification: * **High Richness (Face-to-Face, Video, Telephone):** Highest possible richness. Two-way process; allows for real-time confirmation of understanding. Use whenever time/logistics permit. * **Medium-High Richness (Voicemails):** Slightly higher than email because it conveys intonation, emphasis, and emotional state. * **Moderate/Lower Richness (Email, Online Discussion):** Email is common but often lacks tone, leading to ambiguity. Online discussions are slightly better than email due to the "discussion" element. * **Low Richness (Reports, Bulletins, Memos, Pre-recorded Speeches):** High noise, no immediate feedback, and inability to gauge the recipient's reaction.

Small-Group Networks & Evaluation:

Criteria	Chain	Networks Wheel	All Channel
Speed	Moderate	Fast	Fast
Accuracy	High	High	Moderate
Emergence of a leader	Moderate	High	None
Member satisfaction	Moderate	Low	High

Forms of Communication: * **Oral Communication:** Speeches, formal discussions, informal rumor mills (Grapevine), meetings, video-conferencing, and telephone. * **Written Communication:** Letters, presentations, email, instant messaging, text messaging, and social media.

Tricky Logic & Traps

- **Group vs. Team Distinction:** Students must distinguish based on "Synergy" and "Accountability." Groups are for information sharing; teams are for collective performance. Team synergy is always positive; group synergy can be neutral or negative.
- **Mutual vs. Individual Accountability:** In groups, accountability is individual. In teams, because they are "bonded" and "carefully chosen," accountability is mutual.
- **Complementary Skills vs. Equal Talent:** A common mistake is assuming a team is just a group of high performers. To achieve synergy, a team must have **complementary skills** (where "pluses and minuses offer offset"). A team of four equally skilled people may not justify a team structure.
- **Self-managed Team Risks:** These are not "leadership-free" in the sense of being easy; they are prone to conflict and communication lapses specifically because they lack formal authority and clear structures.
- **Virtual Team Trade-offs:** While they save on travel/time, they create a "visibility" gap. Individuals must work harder to "market" their work, and the lack of physical proximity can lead to slower decision-making in urgent situations.
- **Creator vs. Promoter Distinction:** Do not assume both roles require the same skillset. A **Creator** is characterized by "out of the box" thinking; a **Promoter** is characterized by the ability to champion and communicate that idea to others.
- **Managerial Evaluation (The "Gap" Test):** A manager's effectiveness can be assessed by the "gap" in team roles. If a team is tasked with a goal but lacks a specific role (e.g., no Creator or no Linker), it is a failure of the manager's ability to select/form the team.
- **Project Aristotle "Who" vs. "How":** The "who" (personality types, specific skills, or diverse backgrounds) did not determine success. Success was determined by "how" the team functioned: **Equality** (everyone speaks roughly the same amount) and **Social Sensitivity** (reading non-verbal cues).
- **Psychological Safety vs. Skill:** Psychological safety is considered more significant than a member's actual ability or personality. It creates a "safety net" where individuals feel comfortable despite their "hardships" or "flaws."
- **The "Intelligence/Anxiety" Trap:** Be careful with the assumption that "intelligent" people are always confident. One study showed that if we believe our peers are smarter, it triggers anxiety that "blocks" our ability to think effectively—literally making the individual "dumber" in that moment.
- **Gender and Social Attunement:** Note that the negative effects of anxiety (as seen in the "Tongue-Tied" case) were found to be worse for women, potentially due to being more "socially attuned."
- **The "Introversion" Myth:** Do not assume introversion is a fixed trait. It is often situational. Large-scale public speaking can "force" an extroverted response by removing the hesitation/shyness of the individual.
- **Grapevine Ambiguity:** The primary risk of the "Grapevine" is not necessarily the content (it may be true), but the **lack of a formal "stamp"** from the organization, which leads to ambiguity and feelings of anxiety.
- **Selection of Communication Channel:** When choosing a channel, the decision must be balanced against **Speed, Accuracy, Emergence of a Leader, and Member Satisfaction**. For example, if a leadership-driven, authoritative message is needed, a **Wheel** network is superior. If member satisfaction and feedback are the priority, an **All-Channel** is superior.
- **The "Tough" Choice of Team vs. Individual:** A common mistake is assuming teams are always the best option. If a task does not involve **interdependence**, an individual contributor is the more efficient and appropriate choice.

Social Media Dynamics:

- **Control vs. Reach:** Executives are often wary because they cannot control the outcome of social media posts.
- **Intellectual Capital Leak:** A major risk is the "leak" of proprietary info; clear policies on what can be shared are required.

- **"Stale" Content:** Posting outdated information suggests a lack of engagement and sends a negative message about the organization.
- **The "Truth" Defense:** People often treat their personal interpretations as "Facts." To bypass this, a manager must frame their communication as an "Opinion" (e.g., "The way I see it...").
- **Ambiguity of Digital Media:** The lack of non-verbal cues (body language, tone) in emails and texts leads to higher risk of anxiety and misinterpretation compared to oral communication.
- **Physical Distance & Culture:** While physical distance can signal engagement or aggression, it is heavily influenced by cultural norms; these must be respected to maintain cordial communication.

Exam Pointers

None yet.

Sources

MBAZG511_Managing People and Organization - Lectures 10-16 (2).pdf MBAZG511_Managing People and Organization - Lectures 10-16.pdf MPO Session 9-13 2026.pdf